

EUMENIDES

CHARACTERS

THE PYTHIA priestess of Apollo at Delphi

APOLLO son of Zeus, god of prophecy and purification

ORESTES son of Agamemnon and Clytemnestra

CLYTEMNESTRA killed by Orestes, now a ghost

CHORUS of the Erinyes of Clytemnestra

ATHENA daughter of Zeus, patron goddess of Athens

ATHENIAN CITIZEN-JURORS

ATHENIAN WOMEN

The scene is at Delphi, before the oracular temple of Apollo. His priestess, the PYTHIA, enters from the right.

PYTHIA Among the gods I honor in my prayer,
I give first place to the first prophet, Earth,
and second place to Themis, the second one
to hold her mother's seat of prophecy,
or so the story goes. Then third in line,
by Themis' own choice and not by force,
another Titaness took her place: Phoebe,
child of earth, and she in turn gave it
to Phoebus for his birthday, which is why
he added her name to his own.

Leaving
the pool and spiny ridge of Delos, he sailed
into the ship-hive coast of Pallas and came here
to this land to make his home on Mount Parnassus.
The children of Hephaestus, road-makers
who tamed the land that was untamed before,
escorted him with deepest reverence.
The people honored him greatly at his coming,
as Delphus did, the country's king and helmsman.
And Zeus infused him with the prophet's art,
and put him as the fourth seer on this throne.
Apollo, then, is spokesman for his father Zeus.

I make these gods the prelude of my prayer,
yet in all I say I also honor Pallas
whose shrine stands there, apart, and revere the

Nymphs
whose dwelling is the hollowed Corycian rock,
sweet haunt of birds and spirits lingering.
And Bromius too (I don't forget) has held
sway in this region ever since the day
he, in his true form, led his troop of women,
his wild bacchantes, to hunt down Pentheus,

to snare him like a hare in a net of death.
 I call on the streams of Pleistus in the gorge below,
 and on Poseidon's power, and on Zeus,
 who brings all to fulfillment, the Most High.
 And as I take my seat to prophesy,
 may they all grant me foresight that exceeds
 whatever foresight I have had before.
 If there are any Greeks here, let them enter
 in order of the lots they drew, as the custom is.
 My prophecies will follow where the god leads.

40

*The PYTHIA enters the temple, then immediately returns,
 but now crawling at first on hands and knees.*

Terror for tongue to tell of, for eyes to see,
 sheer terror has driven me away, again,
 from Apollo's house, so that my strength falters,
 and I can't stand on my own two legs, and
 I go on all fours, trembling, inch by inch,
 because a terrified old woman's nothing
 at all, no better than a child.

I was
 making my way into the inner chamber
 where the air glows green from the garlands left there
 when I saw a man polluted before the gods
 sitting the way a suppliant would sit
 on the navel stone, blood dripping from his hands,
 blood also dripping from his just drawn sword;
 he held a tall branch of an olive tree
 wreathed as it should be with a shock of wool,
 the white fleece radiant—this I can say for sure.
 But an astounding gang of women sleeps
 around him, all slouched in chairs. Women?
 No, not women. Gorgons maybe, but, no,
 not even Gorgon shapes could do them justice.
 I saw a painting once of flying female-
 creatures snatching food from Phineus,
 but this gang has no wings, and they're all black,

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60

disgusting, and their phlegmy snores spew out
 a stink that blinds and repels, and their eyes drip
 a sickening ooze. Their dark rags, too, aren't fit
 to wear before the statues of the gods,
 or even right to bring into the house.
 I've never seen the tribe this crew belongs to,
 or known a land that could rear a brood like this
 and not be damaged and regret the labor.
 How this will end up now is his concern,
 the master of the house, great Loxias
 himself, the wily one. He is the prophet,
 the healer; he scans the signs to see what is
 to come; he has the power to purify.

70

*The PYTHIA exits to the right. APOLLO and
 ORESTES enter from the temple.*

APOLLO I won't betray you. Your guardian to the end,
 both when I'm here with you and far away—
 I won't ease up against your enemies.
 See how I've tamed, for now, these crazed hags,
 lulled them to sleep, these maidens of filth, these
 wrinkled
 children no god, or man, or any beast
 would want to touch: born evil, born for evil,
 their only dwelling place the evil darkness
 of the deepest underground, despised
 alike by men and all the gods above.
 They're tamed for now. But flee them, don't let up,
 for they will dog you, there at your heels, as you run
 on from horizon to horizon, fast
 at your pounding heels, over the vast mainland,
 and across the sea to sea-encircled cities.
 Don't tire or lose heart till you've shepherded
 your hard task all the way to Pallas Athena's
 city. Once there, sit as a suppliant,
 holding her age-old image in your arms.
 And we'll have judges for your case, and words

80

90

that spellbind; we will find the means to free you
from this toil you've been caught in, once and for all.
For I persuaded you to kill your mother.

ORESTES My lord Apollo, you know how not to be 100
unjust; learn, too, how not to be neglectful.
Your strength assures me of your power for good.

APOLLO Remember, don't let fear overtake you.
Now, Hermes, my brother, son of my father too,
watch over him; be your own namesake and
escort him, guide him well, for he's my suppliant,
and Zeus honors the rights of outcasts who are blessed
with such a guide back to the world of men.

*ORESTES exits to the left and APOLLO enters the
temple. After a brief pause, CLYTEMNESTRA's
ghost appears, perhaps on the roof
of the stage building.*

CLYTEMNESTRA Keep sleeping! You there! Ah, what good are you 110
to me asleep? Because of you I go
dishonored among the other dead. The spirits
of those I killed won't stop accusing me,
I wander in disgrace. I tell you, day
and night they hector me with blame. And though
I too have suffered from my blood relations,
none of the gods is angry on my behalf,
though I was slaughtered by my own son's hands.
Picture my wounds in your heart (for the sleeping
mind
can see more clearly than the mind awake).
Remember where they came from, and don't forget 120
how many offerings I made to you,
how you would lap them up, the wineless pourings,
sober propitiations, holy feasts
burned in a hearth pit in the darkest recess
of the night, at an hour not shared by other gods—
And all for what? To see my offerings trampled

while I watch him slip away so easily
 and vanish like a fawn, watch him leap free
 out from the middle of your net, and taunt you,
 mock you, winking, as he bounds off? Hear me!
 My very being hinges on my plea.
 Wake up now, goddesses from beneath the ground,
 for I am Clytemnestra, the dream that calls you.

130

(whining from within the temple)

The more you whine, the farther away he gets,
 for *his* friends, unlike mine, know how to help.

(more whining)

More sleep's in you than pity for my pain.
 Orestes, who ran me—his mother!—through, is gone.

(moaning)

How can you sleep and moan like this? Get up!
 Get up! Ruin's the job you're meant to do!

(more moaning)

Sleep and exhaustion, those arch-conspirators,
 have drained the poison from the dread snake's tooth.

140

CHORUS *(moaning twice as loud, still from within)* Get him!
 Get him! Get him! There! Over there!

CLYTEMNESTRA The quarry you keep hunting's just a dream,
 and yet you still bay like a hound that can't
 stop sniffing out the bloodtrail. What are you doing?
 Get up! Don't let exhaustion overcome you!
 Don't let sleep slacken your pace, make you forget
 my misery! Let my just accusations
 sting your heart awake, for they are sharp
 goads to the sensible. Breathe over him the blood-
 reek of your breath, shrivel him in the sizzling

150

gust of your belly's fire! Get after him,
wither him away with a fresh pursuit!

(CLYTEMNESTRA'S GHOST DISAPPEARS. *The* CHORUS
enters from the temple by ones and twos.)

CHORUS Up now! Wake her, just as I wake you!
Still sleeping? Come on, get up! Kick sleep away,
let's see if this dream is a truthful prelude.

IOU! IOU! POPAX *Strophe 1*

Wronged, sorely wronged, my sisters,
Oh I have suffered so much, and for what?

Yes we have suffered 160
such searing pain, oh yes, a hurt
no one could bear,
the beast has slipped free of the net and vanished:
sleep took me, and the prey is lost.

O child of Zeus, you thief! So young *Antistrophe 1*
yet you have trampled down the gray gods

by guarding the suppliant,
the godless, the mother-hating man.

A god yourself,
you've spirited away the mother-killer. 170
Could anyone call these actions just?

Blame came to me in my dream—over
and over

it struck me like a charioteer, *Strophe 2*
with the goad gripped
tight in his fist; in the heart, in the guts,
it struck, and I feel
the cold sting of the scourger's cruel
quick public lash.

This is what all of you do, you younger
gods,

your power knows no bounds, respects none. *Antistrophe 2*

Gore oozes over 180

Apollo's throne, from the top, to the bottom,
 it drips, and I see
 the earth's stone navel smeared with filth
 from bloody deeds.

A prophet himself, he's dirtied his own
 shrine,
 defiled his hearth
 at no one's bidding but his own,
 invited blight
 by placing men above the god-
 set limits, breaking
 the age-old power of the fates.

Strophe 3

190

Although he hurts me too, he still won't
 save
 Orestes, never;
 for even hid beneath the earth,
 this suppliant
 will not escape, but come stained,
 cursed, to where
 a new avenger will rise against him.

Antistrophe 3

APOLLO enters from the temple.

APOLLO Get out of this house, right now, I order you!
 Away from my temple's deep prophetic chamber
 or you'll be bitten by a flying snake
 shot from my bowstring's beaten gold, and retch
 in agony, coughing up all the black
 scum sucked from men, the clotted gore you guzzled.
 You have no rights here, no business in this house,
 your jurisdiction is where heads are lopped off
 in retribution, eyes gouged out, throats slashed;
 where the manhood of mere boys is cut away,
 their seed squandered, and men—their hands, their
 feet,
 their ears and nose—are maimed, and they are stoned
 to death, and where they feel the sharp stake driven
 into their backs and groan out loud and long.

200

210

Don't you hear then what sort of feasts you crave
 that make the gods despise you? Your very shape
 and dress explain it. Creatures like you belong
 in caves with blood-befouled, blood-lapping lions;
 you have no business in this prophetic place,
 rubbing your stinking dirt off on those near you.
 Get out of here, you herd without a herdsman!
 No god would ever tend a flock like this.

220

CHORUS LEADER It's your turn now to listen, lord Apollo.
 You are no mere accessory to this crime;
 From start to finish, the blame is yours alone.

APOLLO How so? Say just enough to make it clear.

CHORUS LEADER You told your guest-friend he should kill his mother.

APOLLO I told him to avenge his father. What else?

CHORUS LEADER You took him in, blood still wet on his hands.

APOLLO I told him to come for cleansing to this shrine.

CHORUS LEADER And you malign us for serving as his escort?

230

APOLLO You aren't fit creatures to come near my house.

CHORUS LEADER But we as well have our appointed task . . .

APOLLO Appointed? You? Crow on about this noble job.

CHORUS LEADER We hound all mother-killers from their houses.

APOLLO And what about a wife who kills her husband?

CHORUS LEADER That isn't killing one's own flesh and blood.

APOLLO Why, then, you spit on, treat as less than nothing,
 the solemn vows of Hera, the fulfiller,
 and of Zeus; and Aphrodite, too, is thrown

away like something worthless by your words, 240
 yes, Aphrodite who gives to humankind
 the deepest and most intimate bond of all.
 Marriage is a thing of destiny,
 greater than any oath, and Justice guards it.
 And so if you let spouses kill each other
 and overlook it, neither punishing them
 nor looking on them with a wrathful vigilance,
 then I maintain this hounding of Orestes
 isn't just. It's clear to me you're stirred 250
 to utter outrage by the one crime while
 the other doesn't move you in the least.
 But Pallas, goddess of wisdom that she is,
 will oversee the issue of this case.

CHORUS LEADER We'll never stop harassing him, not ever.

APOLLO Go on, then. Make more trouble for yourself.

CHORUS LEADER Don't try to steal our rights with clever words.

APOLLO If someone gave me your rights, I wouldn't take them.

CHORUS LEADER Why should you, high and mighty as you seem
 near Zeus's throne? But the scent of motherblood
 drives us,
 and we will hunt the man down, get our justice. 260

The CHORUS exits to the left.

APOLLO And I will help my suppliant and save him.
 A suppliant's wrath's a dreadful thing for gods
 and men alike. I never will betray him.

*APOLLO exits into the temple. There is a
 brief pause. The scene is now set in Athens.
 ORESTES enters from the left.*

ORESTES Queen Athena, I have come at Apollo's
 command. Receive me graciously, a cursed,
 a hounded man, but one no longer stained,
 my hands now clean, my guilt's keen edge now
 dulled,
 worn down to nothing by the crowded paths
 I've traveled, by the homes I've sheltered in.
 Holding a firm course over both sea and land,
 obedient to Apollo's orders, I've come
 at last, goddess, here to your house, your image,
 watching and waiting for justice to be fulfilled.

270

*The CHORUS enters by ones and twos,
 miming hounds tracking a scent.*

CHORUS LEADER So, finally, a clear sign of the man.
 Here, this way, this is where the voiceless snitch
 is leading! Like a blood hound on the scent
 of a wounded fawn, we track him by this trail
 of blood drops. And he's panting out his guts
 from all the endless deadly labors, driven
 like a sheep over every stretch of land
 while we flew wingless, faster than any ship,
 across sea after sea, pursuing. I know
 he's cowering somewhere near here, for the scent
 of blood is like the warm smile of an old friend.

280

CHORUS Look! Look again!
 Check everywhere—
 don't let the mother-killer slip through our clutches
 and get away unpunished.

There he is, himself, there in the flesh!
 and once again
 protected, his arms around the image
 of the immortal goddess,
 eager to stand trial for his crime.
 But that won't happen. Once a mother's blood
 is spilled on the ground,

290

it can't return again, not ever.

POPOI! The red
stream pools there, seeps into earth, and then
it's gone for good.
You'll have to pay with your own blood for hers,
you'll feel me suck the half-
caked gore out of your living flesh;
swill from your very veins
the vile dregs of the drink I crave.
I'll shrivel you up and drag you, still alive,
into the underworld
where you will pay in currencies of torment
for the murder of your mother.
And there you'll see all other mortal sinners,
the ones who flout
the honor owed to gods or guests,
or loving parents —
you'll see them get the justice they deserve.
For Hades holds men mightily to a strict
accounting down below the earth;
he sees all things, inscribes them
within the book
of his remembering.

ORESTES I have been schooled by my own suffering:
I've learned the many ways of being purged.
I know where words are proper, and when silence is,
and that on this occasion a wise teacher
has ordered me to speak. For the blood drowns,
sloughs from my hand, the stain of having killed
my mother has been entirely washed away:
when it was still fresh at Apollo's hearth,
he cast it out by sacrificing swine.
My story would be a long one if I told it
right from the start, the many men I met
and mingled with, not one of whom was harmed.
Time cleanses what it touches over time.
So now with clean lips and well-omened words
I call Athena, this land's queen, to be

my savior. Not by force of spear or sword,
 she'll claim me, my land, and all the people of Argos,
 as her true allies till the end of time.
 Wherever she is—whether in distant Libya,
 there by the stream of Triton where she was born,
 enthroned or on the march to help her friends,
 or whether like a dauntless leader she over-
 sees the Phlegrean plain—O let her come
 (a god can hear even from far away),
 and save me from the troubles that hound me still.

340

CHORUS LEADER No, not Apollo's, not Athena's strength
 can save you, keep you from going down in disgrace,
 forgotten, no place in your heart for joy, all blood
 sucked from your body till it's nothing but
 death's vaporous feedbag, shadowy husk of air.

So you have nothing to say? You just spit at my
 words—
 calf fattened all for me, my living feast,
 my calf not butchered first over any altar?
 Hear the spell we sing to bind you fast:

350

CHORUS Let's dance as well as sing around him,
 hand in hand,
 and let's reveal the terrifying
 power of our dark melody
 and tell the way our company
 fulfills the offices assigned
 to us, our given
 right to guide the lives of men.
 We keep straight on the path of justice,
 that's our belief:
 our wrath is never aimed at the one
 who holds up hands no blood has stained—
 for *that* one lives out his life unharmed.
 But the man, like this one here before us,
 who tries to keep
 his red hands hid, yet reeks of guilt,

360

will find us ever at his side,
 bearing witness
 truthfully for those who died,
 the court of last appeal, the final
 blood avengers.

370

Mother, O mother Night,
 who bore me as a scourge
 to those under the sun,
 and those in sunlessness,
 hear me. Leto's child,
 Apollo, steals my honor,
 he's trying now to steal
 out of my rightful grasp
 this trembling hare whose blood
 alone is the atonement
 for the motherblood he spilled.

Strophe 1

380

Over our victim's head,
 this is the song we sing,
 this is the maddening song,
 the raging song of fear
 that twists the brain, that binds it,
 the lyre-shunning song
 of the Erinyes, draining,
 withering life away.

Refrain 1

390

When Fate, the all-directing,
 spun the unchangeable, ever-
 piercing thread of life,
 this was the task she gave
 us to be ours forever:
 those whom rage seizes, who
 willfully kill their own
 kin with their own hands, we
 will hound them, drive them down
 beneath the earth, and even
 in death they'll find scant freedom.

Antistrophe 1

400

Over our victim's head,
 this is the song we sing,
 this is the maddening song,
 the raging song of fear
 that twists the brain, that binds it,
 the lyre-shunning song
 of the Erinyes, draining,
 withering life away.

Refrain 1

410

Yes, at our birth, we were given this holy
 task.

Strophe 2

So the high gods steer clear of us, and we of them.
 None of them would feast with us at the same table;
 we have no part in festivals where white robes are
 worn.

The calling I've made my own
 is the destruction of houses
 when the spirit of Ares, reared,
 tamed, pampered in the home,
 cuts down a loved one. Then
 we hunt the doer down,
 strong though he is, we suck
 his blood away to nothing
 for all the blood he shed.

Refrain 2

420

We are all keen to spare others these troubling
 cares,
 keen, too, to keep the gods from meddling with our
 prayers.

Antistrophe 2

But Zeus despises our band as being soaked in blood
 and calls us unworthy to be part of his high company.

The calling I've made my own
 is the destruction of houses
 when the spirit of Ares, reared,
 tamed, pampered in the home,
 cuts down a loved one. Then
 we hunt the doer down,
 strong though he is, we suck

Refrain 2

430

his blood away to nothing
for all the blood he shed.

But the self-preening conceits of men, swelling
so big *Strophe* 3
under the sun, rot away into earth, all dishonored,
driven
down by the gale of our black robes rushing upon
them,
by the quick kicks of our raging dance.

440

For leaping from a great *Refrain* 3
height I bring the full
force of my foot down
more heavily upon him;
unseen, I thrust out my leg
and even the swiftest runner
stumbles and falls down
to ruin beyond enduring.

But as he falls, his mind so crazed he doesn't know
it— *Antistrophe* 3 450
this the miasmal dark that hovers about the man,
and rumor passes its groan from voice to voice to say
that a dense fog has shrouded his house.

For leaping from a great *Refrain* 3
height I bring the full
force of my foot down
more heavily upon him;
unseen, I thrust out my leg
and even the swiftest runner
stumbles and falls down
to ruin beyond enduring.

460

This stands fixed. Adept at devising, *Strophe* 4
unmatched alike in remembering wrong done
as in repaying it;
awful to men, deaf to their pleas,
detested and dishonored we fulfill

our given office; cut off
 from the gods, we in the dark slime make
 the path rough both for those who live in sunlight
 and for those in sunlessness.

470

Who among mortals is immune *Antistrophe 4*
 to feeling awe and fear when I describe
 the covenant that fate
 assigned me, that the gods made final?
 My privileges, ancient as they are,
 remain still no less mine.
 And I am no less honored for
 the station that I hold beneath the ground
 deep in the sunless slime.

*ATHENA enters from the left, in full
 armor and wearing her aegis.*

ATHENA From the Scamander far away I heard
 your call for help, as I took possession there
 of land that the Achaean chieftains gave me,
 all completely and forever mine,
 a rich allotment from the spoils of war,
 and a precious gift for Theseus' sons.
 From there I sped, my stride unwearied, wingless
 but for the flap and billow of the folds
 my aegis made.

480

But now I see a strange
 and motley crew of visitors to this land.
 Though I feel no fear, my eyes grow wide with
 wonder.

490

Who are you? I mean all of you together—
 you stranger with your arms around my image,
 and you who look like nothing ever born—
 not seen by gods among the goddesses,
 or shaped in any human form. But, no,
 it isn't just to speak ill of another
 when he's done nothing wrong; Right won't abide it.

CHORUS LEADER Daughter of Zeus, you'll learn all, in a few words:
we are the children of the never-dying Night.
In our homes beneath the earth we're known as
"Curses."

500

ATHENA I now know your descent, and your true names.

CHORUS LEADER And soon you'll learn our privileges as well.

ATHENA I will, yes, if you tell them to me plainly.

CHORUS LEADER We hound from home the ones who kill their own.

ATHENA Do you chase the killer to some final place?

CHORUS LEADER A place where all joy is unknown to him.

ATHENA And this man here, you howl him on that far?

CHORUS LEADER Yes, since he thought it right to kill his mother.

ATHENA Was he made to do it, fearing some other anger?

CHORUS LEADER What spur's so sharp to make one kill his mother?

510

ATHENA The case has two sides; so far we've heard just one.

CHORUS LEADER He won't swear he's innocent, or yield if I swear to his
guilt.

ATHENA So you would rather seem just than act with justice?

CHORUS LEADER How so? Tell me. For you are rich in wisdom.

ATHENA Injustice shouldn't triumph on an oath.

CHORUS LEADER Then question him yourself. And judge him fairly.

ATHENA You'd take my verdict as the final one?

CHORUS LEADER Yes. We pay you the respect you pay to us.

ATHENA It's your turn, stranger. How will you answer them?
Say first where you come from, who your family is. 520
Explain your circumstances, and then refute
these accusations. If you're sure you sit
in justice near my hearth, clutching my image —
as a holy suppliant, like Ixion before you,
then answer clearly, so I understand.

ORESTES Queen Athena, let me speak first
to the keen anxiety your last words hold.
I'm not a suppliant in need of cleansing.
When I took my seat here at your image,
my hands weren't stained with blood. And I can prove 530
my claim with powerful evidence: by law,
a killer is forbidden to speak a word
till someone with the power to purify
has washed away his blood-guilt with the blood
of a young beast. I have been long since purged
at other houses, both in the blood of sucklings
slain to cleanse me, and in clear-running streams.
My hands are clean. Put your mind at ease.
Now I can tell you straight out where I come from,
who my family is: I am from Argos, 540
and my father, Agamemnon, you know well
as warlord of the fleet who helped you turn
the city of Troy into no city at all.
When he came home, he died an ugly death:
my black-hearted mother cut him down,
wrapped him in her subtle net, a net that
bore witness to the blood bath of his murder.
So I returned, after my years of exile,
and killed the very woman who gave me life —
I don't deny it — killed her for killing him, 550
the father I loved — although Apollo, too, had
an equal hand in this, for he had goaded

me on with warnings of heart-piercing pain
 if I failed to get revenge on the murderers.
 But it's all up to you now to decide
 whether I've acted justly or not. However
 the case turns out, I will accept your ruling.

ATHENA This case is too hard for one man to judge.
 No, even I don't have the right to rule
 on a murder trial like this one, one
 that calls down such fierce anger either way,
 especially as you've come here to my house
 a proper suppliant who's clean, who bears
 no danger to us, and I welcome you.
 And yet these, too, have their appointed task
 that can't be shrugged off lightly. If they fail
 to get their way, the poison of their outrage,
 dripping on the land, will soon become
 a deadly everlasting sickness. But since
 the problem's up to me to solve, I'll choose
 a panel of judges to preside at murder
 trials like this, and put them under oath,
 and so set up a court to last forever.
 Now call your witnesses, prepare your proofs,
 bring forth whatever evidence you have
 that best supports your case. Meanwhile, I'll pick
 my ablest citizens, and then return
 to deal with this matter fairly, once and for all.

ATHENA *exits to the right.* ORESTES *stands aside during
 the following song.*

CHORUS Catastrophes will come,
 disasters of new laws, if
 the mother-killer's mayhem-
 making plea prevails.
 This deed, from this time on,
 will make men poised for any
 and all outrageousness.
 Truly, parents will await

Strophe 1

in time to come the keen
edge of a blade thrust
home by their own child's hand.

And we, wild revelers, who keep
a close watch over all
men do, will never again
attack them in anger. We'll
let any murder pass:
and one man, seeing his neighbor
suffer, will ask another,
"When will the sickness ease,
or end?" Poor wretch, the balm
he hopes heals evil won't,
and he'll hope in vain.

Antistrophe 1 590

600

From now on let no one
struck by disaster cry
for help, call out in terror:
"O Justice! O Erinyes,
enthroned in majesty!"
Caught unaware by pain,
some father or mother now
will cry like this, because
the house of Justice falls.

Strophe 2

There is a place where dread
is good, and must abide
to keep watch over all
men think. It's for the best
that wisdom comes from wailing.
What man, or city even,
whose heart's not fed on fear,
would ever again pay Justice
the reverence she's owed?

Antistrophe 2 610

Praise no life that no law reins,
no life a tyrant rules.
God gives

Strophe 3

620

victory always to the middle way,
 even while seeing to it
 differently in different spheres.
 Be moderate, I say:
 truly, sacrilege
 gives birth to recklessness,
 but a well mind breeds
 what we all love and pray for—
 a lasting, a rich well-being.

630

I tell you, then, revere,
 in all you do, the altar
 of Justice.
 don't kick it over in a wild forgetfulness,
 fixing your hungry gaze
 on some brief gain beyond it.
 Vengeance will track you down.
 The inevitable waits.
 Knowing this, first honor
 your parents, then respect
 the guest you welcome in.

Antistrophe 3

640

And doing this you will be just
 by choice, not by compulsion, and never lack
 well-being—you and yours
 will never be dragged down into dirt.
 But the wild man, I tell you, shamelessly defiant
 in the face of justice, hauling
 his plunder off—he'll be compelled,
 in time, to lower his sails when the storm grips him
 and his yardarm snaps and shatters.

Strophe 4

650

He calls to those who will not hear him
 as he wrestles to get a grip on whirling water,
 and the god howls with laughter
 to see him there, the bold and cocky man
 who'd brag that no bad thing could ever touch him
 and now flails, battered by sorrows,
 waves rising insurmountably around him.

Antistrophe 4

His lifelong wealth breaks up on the reef of Justice,
and he sinks, unwept, unseen.

*ATHENA enter from the rights, accompanied by a group
of Athenian citizen-jurors.*

ATHENA Herald, declare the court in session, call
the people to their places, and let the piercing
Etruscan trumpet, dense with human breath,
blare out its shrill voice to the assembly.
While the court is filling, it is right
that everyone be silent, so that both
the city and these jurors learn the laws
I've fashioned for all time; in that way those
who stand here will receive a just decision.

660

APOLLO enters from the left.

My lord Apollo, take charge of your own affairs:
What role have you played in this matter? Tell us.

670

APOLLO I am here as a witness: when this man
came in supplication to my house
and hearth, as is the custom, I purged him
of the blood he shed. And I am also here
to represent him, for I ordered him
to kill his mother. I am responsible.
Now start the trial, Athena. Take it in hand,
as you know how to do, and set it right.

ATHENA The case is now before us. Plaintiffs speak first.
It's only right you should, for the pursuer,
telling the story from beginning to end,
can best explain the nature of the case.

680

CHORUS LEADER Though we are many, we'll keep our speeches short.

(addressing ORESTES)

Answer our charges, each one, as we present it:
First, did you kill your mother? Yes or no.

ORESTES Yes, I killed her. I never said I didn't.

CHORUS LEADER The first fall goes to us. Two more to go.

ORESTES Or so you boast, but no one's thrown me yet.

CHORUS LEADER Then tell us how you killed her, since you must.

ORESTES Yes. I drew my sword and slit her throat.

690

CHORUS LEADER By whose persuasion? By whose sage advice?

ORESTES By this god's oracle. He is my witness.

CHORUS LEADER The god taught you it's right to kill your mother?

ORESTES Yes, and till now I have nothing to complain of.

CHORUS LEADER But when the verdict snares you, you'll change your
tune.

ORESTES I trust him; and my father will help me from the
grave.

CHORUS LEADER Good, kill your mother, and then trust in corpses!

ORESTES Yes, I killed her since she was doubly defiled.

CHORUS LEADER How exactly? Explain it to the judges.

ORESTES She killed my father when she killed her husband.

700

CHORUS LEADER Death freed her from her guilt, but you're still living.

ORESTES Why didn't you hunt her down while she still lived?

CHORUS LEADER The man she killed was not her flesh and blood.

ORESTES You think I have the same blood as my mother's?

CHORUS LEADER How else could she have fed you in her womb,
you killer? You spurn the mother blood you live by?

ORESTES Now testify, Apollo, on my behalf
and teach the law to show whether I did
or didn't act with justice when I killed her—
for I did kill her, that I don't deny.
But you determine whether or not this blood
was justly shed, so I can make my case.

710

APOLLO I say to all of you, to this high court
established by Athena, he acted justly.
I am a prophet; I can never lie.
Not once from my far seeing throne have I
said anything concerning a man, a woman,
or even a city that Zeus himself, father
of the Olympians, did not command.
Be mindful of how powerful this plea
for justice is. Follow my father's will.
No oath is stronger than almighty Zeus.

720

CHORUS LEADER So you want us to believe that Zeus gave you
this oracle to pass on to Orestes,
told him to avenge his father's murder
and, in the process, cast aside, trample
to nothing, the respect he owed his mother?

APOLLO Yes, I do. For it's a different thing
entirely when a noble man who holds
the scepter Zeus bestows is murdered, struck down
not even by the far-shot arrow of
some Amazon, but by a woman's hand,
and in a manner I'll describe to you,
Athena, and to all you seated here

730

to judge the case by vote. Once he returned
 from war where he did well enough, on balance,
 the woman made a show of being kind,
 seemed anxious to please him, fuss over him like a
 wife,
 until, as he was stepping from the bath,
 there at the very end, she swaddled him
 in a winding cloth, tangling him up from head
 to toe within the endless fold on fold
 of the embroidered robe, then struck him down.
 This is how wretchedly he died, a man
 all men revered, commander of the fleet.
 I've spoken as I have to whip up anger
 in you who are called to set this matter right.

740

CHORUS LEADER So it's your view that Zeus's main concern
 is for a father's death. Yet didn't he
 himself chain up his aged father, Cronus?
 How do you square this with your argument?
 Heed what you just heard, judges. Remember it.

750

APOLLO You stinking, hideous filth, shunned by the gods,
 we can break bonds, we can slip out of shackles!
 There's
 a cure for ills like those, yes, countless ways
 of getting free. But once a man is dead,
 and the ground has sucked dry all his blood,
 nothing can ever raise him up again.
 My father made no healing spell for that,
 though he can turn all other things, at will,
 inside and out, and not pant from the effort.

760

CHORUS LEADER See where your way of pleading for this man
 has led you: he has spilled his mother's dear
 blood on the ground—so how can he live in Argos,
 take possession of his father's house?
 What public altars could he use? How can he touch
 the cleansing water at his kinsmen's shrine?

APOLLO I'll tell you something else, to show how right
 I am: the so-called mother of the child
 isn't the child's begetter, but only a sort
 of nursing soil for the new-sown seed.
 The man, the one on top, is the true parent,
 while she, a stranger, fosters a stranger's sprout,
 if no god blights it. And I can prove it to you:
 a father can give birth without a mother.
 And here before us is our witness, child
 of Olympian Zeus, daughter who never fed
 and grew within the darkness of a womb,
 a seedling that no goddess could bring forth.
 In all things, Pallas, and with all my power,
 I'll glorify your people and your city;
 for that's the very reason I sent this man
 here to your house and hearth so he could be
 a constant friend to you for all time to come,
 a friend and ally, goddess, he and his heirs,
 each one of their descendents who will keep
 this sacred bond, this covenant forever.

770

780

ATHENA Have we now heard enough? Should I tell these
 judges
 to cast their votes where they think justice lies?

APOLLO Our quiver's empty, all our arrows shot.
 I'll wait to see which way the trial goes.

790

ATHENA

(turning to the CHORUS)

And what must I do now to avoid your reproach?

CHORUS LEADER You've heard what you've heard, and as you vote, my
 friends,
 with all your heart respect the oath you've sworn.

ATHENA Now hear my ordinance, you men of Athens,
 you who have been chosen to decide

this first trial ever for the shedding of blood.
 Now and in future time, this court of judges
 will continue to exist for the people of Aegeus,
 here on this hill of Ares where the Amazons
 pitched their tents when they invaded, armed,
 and angry at King Theseus, raised up
 against the city the towering walls of their
 own battlements, and slit the throats of beasts
 in sacrifice to Ares. This is why
 we call this place the rock and hill of Ares.
 Here the people's awe and innate fear
 will hold injustice back by day, by night,
 so long as the people leave the laws intact,
 just as they are, and never alter them
 with foul infusions: muddy the cleanest spring,
 and all you'll have to drink is muddy water.
 I urge my people to follow and revere
 neither tyranny nor anarchy,
 and to hold fear close, never to cast it out
 entirely from the city. For what man
 who feels no fear is able to be just?
 And if you fear and justly revere this court,
 then you will have a bulwark for your land,
 the city's guardian, the like of which
 nobody else on earth possesses, not even
 the law-abiding Scythians, or Spartans.
 This council I establish will be immune
 from greed, majestic, poised for wrath, the country's
 wakeful watchman over those who sleep.

I've given this long advice to all my people—
 it's for the future. But now you must stand up,
 take up your ballots and decide the case,
 respecting your sacred oath. My speech is done.

*During the following exchange, the jurors arise,
 proceed to the voting urns, deposit their ballots,
 and return to their seats.*

CHORUS LEADER I warn you all—if you dishonor us,
we'll be a crushing burden on your land. 830

APOLLO And I tell you to fear the oracles,
Zeus's and mine. Don't keep them from bearing fruit.

CHORUS LEADER You honor bloody crimes that aren't your business.
Your oracles will never now be pure.

APOLLO So Zeus made a mistake when Ixion,
the first to kill, appealed to him for help?

CHORUS LEADER You said it, I didn't. But if I don't get justice,
I will come back to crush this land forever.

APOLLO How so? You have no honor among gods,
young or old. I will win this case. 840

CHORUS LEADER You did the same thing, too, in Pheres' house:
you persuaded the Fates to let men hide from death.

APOLLO Is it unjust to treat someone so kindly,
someone that pious, in his time of need?

CHORUS LEADER You overturned the age-old covenant
by duping those ancient goddesses with wine.

APOLLO And when you lose this trial, you'll vomit all
your venom at the ones you hate—quite harmlessly.

CHORUS LEADER Young one, since you would trample down your
elders, 850
I'll have to wait to hear if the court will give me
justice, or the city feel my wrath.

ATHENA My office makes me last to judge this case.
And I will cast my ballot for Orestes.
No mother gave me birth, and in all things
but marriage I wholeheartedly approve

the male—I am entirely my father’s child.
 And this is why the killing of a woman
 who killed her husband, guardian of the house,
 can have no overriding claim on me.
 Orestes wins, even if the votes be equal.

860

(turning to the jurors)

You jurors who have this duty to fulfill,
 quickly spill out the ballots from the urns.

*Two jurors return to the urns and begin the count.
 ATHENA takes a place behind the urns.*

ORESTES Phoebus Apollo, how will it be decided?

CHORUS LEADER Black Night, our mother, are you watching this?

ORESTES It’s time now—to feel the noose, or see the light!

CHORUS LEADER To be disgraced, or forever keep our honors!

APOLLO Count up the spilled out votes precisely, friends,
 make no mistake, be sure the sum is just.
 Out of bad judgment comes catastrophe,
 But when the judgment’s sound, a single vote
 can reestablish order in a house.

870

ATHENA *(examining the ballots)* This man’s acquitted on the
 charge of murder—
 the number of votes for both sides is the same.

ORESTES O Pallas Athena, you have saved my house!
 When I was stripped bare of my homeland,
 you gave it back to me. Now Greeks will say:
 “The man is Argive once again; he lives
 among his father’s holdings by the grace
 of Pallas and Apollo, and of the third,
 the savior, he who brings all to fulfillment.”

880

Yes he, himself, gave due weight to the way
my father died, and has delivered me
to safety from my mother's advocates.

And now before I leave for home, I swear
to your country and your people, now and forever,
up to the fullest ripening of time
that no helmsman of my realm, spear poised for
battle,
will come against them. Even from my tomb,
I'll torture the transgressors of this oath
with failure and befuddlement. I'll sap
the spirit from their marches, and beset
their way with ominous wingbeats, so that they
regret they ever did what they have done.
But only if they keep an upright course,
and give enduring honor to the city
of Pallas with their loyal spears, will I
remain a blessing to them.

890

And so goodbye
to you, and to the people of your city.
May the hold you get on all your enemies
allow them no escape, and keep you safe,
and if war comes bring you the victory.

900

ORESTES *exits to the left, accompanied by* APOLLO.

CHORUS IOU! IOU! You young gods—you
have trampled down the age-old laws,
ripped them out of my hands!
My honor stripped away, enraged,
aggrieved, now I
will squeeze out all the poison in my heart
against the land for all I've suffered,
yes, poison now will ooze and drip
unbearably into the soil.

Refrain 1

And out of it pale fungus
blighting leaf and child (O justice!)
will quicken across

910

the land to cover it and all the people
 in a miasmal fog of
 killing illnesses. Sorrow!
 What can I do? Mocked! Spit on
 by the citizens!
 We suffer the insufferable,
 luckless daughters of Night
 who have been wronged, stripped of our honor!

920

ATHENA Let me persuade you not to shoulder such
 a burden of grief—because you weren't defeated,
 the voting in the trial was truly equal;
 you haven't been disgraced, no. After all,
 the evidence from Zeus shown clear, and he
 who gave the oracle bore witness that
 Orestes should not be harmed for what he did.
 So don't be angry; no longer aim your out-
 rage on this land, or send out blight against it,
 the piercing vapors that eat up the seeds.
 I swear wholeheartedly to you, in justice,
 that you will have your seat in a vast cavern
 deep in this land of justice, and there you will sit
 on gleaming thrones beside your sacred altars,
 forever honored by my citizens.

930

CHORUS IOU! IOU! You young gods—you *Refrain 1*
 have trampled down the age-old laws,
 ripped them out of my hands!
 My honor stripped away, enraged,
 aggrieved, now I
 will squeeze out all the poison in my heart
 against the land for all I've suffered,
 yes, poison now will ooze and drip
 unbearably into the soil.
 And out of it pale fungus
 blighting leaf and child (O justice!)
 will quicken across
 the land to cover it and all the people
 in a miasmal fog

940

950

of killing illnesses. Sorrow!
 What can I do? Mocked! Spit on
 by the citizens!
 We suffer the insufferable,
 luckless daughters of Night
 who have been wronged, stripped of our honor!

ATHENA Not stripped of honor, no. You're goddesses,
 don't in a rush of anger blast the land
 of mortals. I have Zeus on my side and—
 why even bring it up?—I'm the only one
 among the gods who knows where he keeps the key
 to the chamber in which the lightning bolt is sealed.
 No, we won't have need of that. Please,
 let me persuade you not to spew from foolish
 lips such curses against the land as make
 all things that bear fruit shrivel up and die.
 Soothe into sleep the black wave of your rage,
 its bitter surging: for you'll be honored here,
 and worshipped, and share my home. And when
 you receive the first fruits of this great land
 offered up to you in hope of children
 and for the fulfillment of the marriage rite,
 you'll thank me for this advice I've given you.

960

970

CHORUS That they would do this to me!
 Force me, with all my age-old wisdom,
 under this earth
 like some defiled contaminated thing!
 I'm breathing rage, sheer rage.
 OTOTOTOI POPOI! DA!
 What torture slides down over me
 and through my brain!
 Hear me O mother Night—the gods'
 sleight of hand has snatched
 my ancient rights away and made me
 less than nothing.

Refrain 2

980

ATHENA I'll put up with your anger, for you are much
 older than I am—and, therefore, so much wiser.
 But Zeus has given me a keen mind too,
 and if you leave here for a foreign country 990
 I warn you now you'll long just like a lover
 for this country you have left behind.
 For time as it flows forward will bring great
 and greater honors to the people here,
 And honorably seated near the house
 of Erechtheus, you'll receive from long
 processional of men and women more gifts
 than any other place on earth could give.
 Don't set the inciting whetstone of bloodshed spinning
 throughout my land, sharpening the hearts of young 1000
 men till they're seized by a wildness not of wine.
 Don't make their hearts seethe like the seething hearts
 of fighting cocks, infusing in my people
 a war lust they'll turn inward on each other.
 May all their warfare be with foreigners,
 and may the wars be plentiful enough
 to sate their fiercest hunger for renown.
 There's nothing brave about a cock who fights
 inside the nest.
 So it is your choice now
 to take what I am holding out to you: 1010
 to do well and receive well and, well honored,
 have your own share of this land the gods love well.

CHORUS That they would do this to me! *Refrain 2*
 Force me, with all my age-old wisdom,
 under this earth
 like some defiled contaminated thing!
 I'm breathing rage, sheer rage.
 OTOTOTOI POPOI! DA!
 What torture slides down over me
 and through my brain! 1020
 Hear me O mother night—the gods'
 sleight of hand has snatched

my ancient rights away and made me
less than nothing.

ATHENA I'll never tire of telling you the benefits
I'm offering, so you can never say
that you, an elder goddess, have been disgraced
and driven into exile from this country,
either by me, a younger goddess, or by
the mortal keepers of the city. No!
But if you hold in awe Persuasion's glory,
the power of my tongue to soothe and enchant,
you might live here with us. Still, if you don't,
if you choose not to, it would not be right
to bring the riot of your raging hate
against the city, to harm the people. The way
is free for you to be a landholder here,
enjoying honor justly and forever.

1030

CHORUS LEADER What kind of place would be mine, Queen Athena?

ATHENA One free of pain. Will you make it yours?

1040

CHORUS LEADER And if I do, what honor will I have?

ATHENA No house will ever grow without your blessing.

CHORUS LEADER You'd make me as powerful as that?

ATHENA We'll swell the fortunes of your followers.

CHORUS LEADER You promise me this power's mine forever?

ATHENA I wouldn't promise what I won't fulfill.

CHORUS LEADER You might persuade me; I feel my anger easing.

ATHENA Live with me here, and you'll have more friends, new
friends.

ATHENA Blessings that bring victory without dishonor,
blessings that come from earth, and from the water
of the sea, and from the sky that make the air
across the land breathe out in sunlit breezes;
blessings that make the earth's yield swell, and the
thick
herds grow more bountiful as time goes on
and never fail my people. Their seed, too,
you'll bless and protect, and may you favor most
the purest among them, make them prosper most.
I'm like a gardener, caring for the stock
of these just men, keeping them safe from sorrow.
These are the blessings that are yours to give
while I will shower glory on their battles,
and never fail to let the city's fame
for victory resound in every land.

CHORUS I will accept a home
here in the house of Pallas,
and won't dishonor the city
ruled by Zeus all-mighty
and Ares as the fortress
of the gods, protector of
the altars of the Greeks,
city that all rejoice in,
city for which I pray
and lovingly foretell
that the bright rays of the sun
will make the earth bring forth
in rich profusion all
the good things that foster life.

ATHENA Since my heart is filled with tenderness
for all my people,
I have ensconced these powerful,
demanding goddesses here among them,
goddesses whose task it is

to oversee the lives of men.

And any man
they train their hate on doesn't know

from where the flurry of hard blows
crashes against
his life. Ancestral crime pulls him down
before their judgment seat, and while
he brags out loud, silently
their crushing hatred hits him, their
implacable rage
grinds him completely down to dust.

1090

CHORUS May no fierce wind blast the trees — *Antistrophe 1*
these are my words of grace —
and may no heat that sears
the plants and kills their buds,
cross this land's boundary.
May no blight waste the crops.
May Pan swell the swarming
flocks, double their yield
at the appointed time.
And may the land's children
find veins of wealth within
the soil and honor the gods
with sacrifice for the luck
of their discoveries.

1100

ATHENA Jurors, bulwark of the city,
do you hear what blessings
she'll bring about? The power of the great
Erinyes awes the gods above
and those below, achieves their ends
for all to see, bringing bright
joyous life
to some, life blind with tears to others.

1110

CHORUS I ban, too, the untimely *Strophe 2*
killing of young men;

and you gods who possess
 the power to do so, let
 young girls find husbands—
 especially you Fates,
 our sisters from one mother,
 goddesses whose share is just,
 who have a hand in every
 home, whose force weighs
 heavily in every season,
 whose reckoning, exact
 in all ways is in all
 ways honored by the gods.

ATHENA They bless my land so lovingly
 that my heart swells.
 I'm glad Persuasion's eye watched over
 my lips and tongue when I first faced
 their brutal "No!" But Zeus who guides
 men's speech won out. Our rivalry
 in doing good
 gives victory to good forever.

CHORUS I pray that the crazed voice
 of civil strife that feeds
 on evil and is never full
 may never roar through this land.
 And may the earth not guzzle
 down the black blood of its people,
 and then, hot for revenge,
 welcome the city's ruin,
 murder paid back with murder.
 Instead let citizens
 give joy for joy,
 loving the common good,
 hating a common foe:
 they'll cure most ills this way.

Antistrophe 2

ATHENA These women, have they the wisdom to find
 a path of blessing?

Then I discern in their dread faces
 great gain for all my people. Revere them,
 be kindly to these kindly ones,
 and you will keep the land and city
 on the straight path
 of justice, and shine in everything.

1160

CHORUS Farewell! Rejoice amid
 the wealth you've earned! Goodbye,
 you people of the city
 dwelling near the throne
 of Zeus, loving the goddess
 who loves you well, wiser
 with every passing day,
 safe in the wings of Pallas
 whose father honors you.

Strophe 3

ATHENA Goodbye to you! I'll go before you
 and show you to
 your chambers by the sacred light
 these escorts hold. Now go, and take
 with you these holy offerings.
 Hurry beneath the ground and hide
 down deep within it
 whatever's harmful to the city;

1170

whatever's to the city's gain
 send up, so she
 may always be triumphant! You sons
 of Cranaus, keepers of the city,
 lead the way for them, our new
 inhabitants, and may the people
 receive with good
 hearts all the goodness they are given.

1180

CHORUS Farewell! Goodbye again
 I say, to everyone
 within the city, gods
 as well as mortals. Watch over

Antistrophe 3

Athena's city well,
 revere my dwelling here
 among you, and the lives
 you lead will give you nothing
 ever to complain of.

1190

*A group of women equal in number to
 the Chorus enters, carrying crimson robes, preceded
 by torchbearers, and followed by one or more sacrificial
 animals led by attendants.*

ATHENA I thank you for the blessings you have spoken.
 I'll lead you by the dancing light of torches
 to your deep chamber underneath the earth,
 accompanied by my attendants, the women appointed
 in justice to guard my image. I invite you
 into the very heart of Theseus' land.
 And now, you honorable band of young
 girls, women, aged ladies, dress them
 as suits their dignity in purple robes,
 and let the torches flare and dance, so that
 they'll always show their kindness to the land
 in blessings that bring glory to our men.

1200

*The ESCORT, made up of the jurors and
 the band of women and led by the torchbearers,
 accompanies the Erinyes to the right.*

ESCORT Go on to your new home, you awesome children
 of Night, you aged children,
 childless children, covetous of honor,
 under a kind escort.
 Hush now, people, all of you, speak well,
 only auspicious words.
 Deep in earth's oldest caverns, you'll be graced
 with worship and sacrifices—
 Hush now, citizens, all of you, speak well,
 only auspicious words.
 Gracious and favoring the land that favors you,

1210

come this way, venerable ones,
radiant in the torch-devouring flame,
rejoicing as you go.
Lift up a joyous cry in rhythm to our song.
There will be peace forever
among the people of Pallas. All-seeing
Zeus and Fate have helped
us make it so. Lift up a joyous cry
together and crown our song!

1220